

Branches of Buddhism

From its beginnings in India, Buddhism spread around eastern and Southeast Asia, where the majority of the world's Buddhists still live. There are also Buddhist communities in other parts of Asia, and in the West. Buddhism has two main strands – Mahayana and Theravada – but other forms of Buddhism with distinctive features have also developed.

Theravada

This branch of Buddhism is closest to the teachings of the Buddha himself. It is dominant in Southeast Asia (Burma, Cambodia, Laos, Sri Lanka, and Thailand). Theravada Buddhists revere the Buddha and do not worship other figures. They aim to become "perfected saints" by following the Eightfold Path and tend to believe that people can reach the state of nirvana only through their own efforts.

Mahayana

This form of Buddhism prevails in China, Korea, Japan, Mongolia, Nepal, and Tibet. A follower's first aim is to become a Bodhisattva, an enlightened being who does not pass into nirvana but remains in this world in order to help others to enlightenment. Mahayana Buddhists therefore place a high value on charity.



Chinese Bodhisattva head

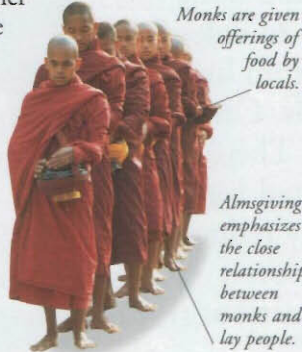
Tibetan Buddhism

A form of Mahayana Buddhism is found in Tibet. Here, special value is placed on the Buddhist virtues of meditation and wisdom. Tibetan Buddhists have their own rituals, such as repeating sacred sayings, or mantras. Since the Chinese invasion of Tibet in the 1950s, few Buddhist monasteries remain in Tibet.



Mantra

Inside a prayer wheel is a mantra that the monk repeats while spinning the wheel.



Monks are given offerings of food by locals.

Almsgiving emphasizes the close relationship between monks and lay people.

Zen

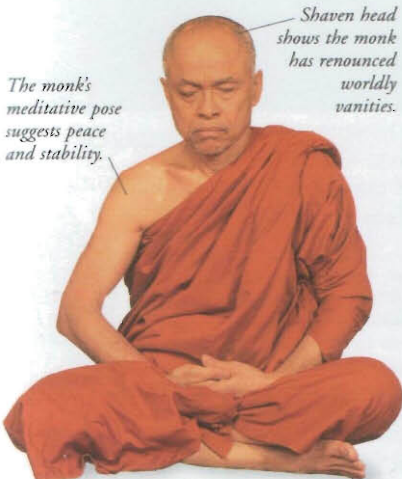
This form of Buddhism originated in China and spread to Japan in about the 13th century. Zen Buddhists aim to lead a simple life, close to nature, using everyday actions as a means of meditation. Zen Buddhists meditate in a way that tries to see beyond logical patterns of thought and preconceived ideas.



A Zen monk tends a garden.

Monasticism

Buddhist monasteries began when the Buddha's followers built permanent settlements to live in together during the rainy season. Today there are many monks (and some nuns) who devote their lives to explaining the Buddha's teachings and setting an example by the way they lead their lives.



The monk's meditative pose suggests peace and stability.

Shaven head shows the monk has renounced worldly vanities.



Sharpening stone

Needle and thread

Razor

Water strainer

Alms bowl lid is also used as a plate.

Alms bowl lid

Alms bowl

Belt or girdle

Living as a monk

Monks live apart from their families and have few personal possessions. They rely on gifts for survival, carrying alms bowls into which people place food. They obey strict rules. They must avoid entertainments in which there is singing or dancing, give up decorative clothes, and eat only at set times.

Sacred texts

Buddhism has sacred texts made up of sayings and sermons, many of them attributed to the Buddha. One of the most important books of writings is the Dhammapada, which forms part of the Pali Canon, the oldest collection of Buddhist scriptures.

In Tibetan-style libraries, manuscripts are wrapped in cloth and placed between boards.



Library in Shey Monastery, Ladakh, India

Temples

The religious buildings of Buddhism vary widely in their shape and decoration, from Japanese pagodas to Thai wats. But all contain statues of the Buddha. The statues act as a focus for devotion and for offerings. People go to the temples to carry out acts of private worship and for special ceremonies.

Devotees gather with their offerings in the grounds of the temple.



Wat Benchamabophit, in Thailand's capital, Bangkok, is known as the marble temple.

Stepped roofs symbolize stages of spiritual development.

Dalai Lama

The Dalai Lama is the spiritual and political leader of Buddhists in Tibet, who believe that each Dalai Lama is a reincarnation of the previous one. The present Dalai Lama, Tenzin Gyatso, was born in 1935. In exile since 1959 following the Chinese takeover, he is still Tibet's most important leader.



FIND OUT MORE

ASIA, HISTORY OF

BUDDHA

CHINA, HISTORY OF

FESTIVALS

MAURYAN EMPIRE

RELIGIONS

SHRINES

SIGNS AND SYMBOLS

THAILAND AND BURMA